



Far Cry will need a powerful, high-end card to look like this



On a low-end card, the same scene at minimum settings. See the difference?

Model 2 only card, and will not allow you to enjoy Shader Model 3 specific effects in the latest games. The 7600GS is also a worthy mid-range consideration for those on a budget—it offers around 60 per cent the performance of the GT based cards, but with a significant price difference—you do the math!

Our Conclusion

The XFX 7600GT ousted the Powercolor X850XT PE by a hairsbreadth to take our Best Buy Gold award. The Powercolor had to be content with the Best Buy Silver title. In terms of performance, the older X850XT chipset is still very competitive in the mid-range segment, but as mentioned earlier, it isn't a future-proof option because of the lack of SM 3 support.

The Forsa 7600GT is a worthy mention: it performed well, and is priced rather attractively. For those with a windowed cabinet, the two unique cards (looks-wise, and both 7600GT chipset based cards from ASUS and MSI) are ideal buys. The MSI 7600GT Diamond actually looks like a 7900GTX card—good flaunt value!

ENTRY-LEVEL GPUS

The most-populated segment—24 cards—was dominated by NVIDIA's 7300GT-based cards and ATI's X1300 chipset. The bestselling 6600GT cards, once mid-range offerings, also find themselves relegated to this category.

Frugal Performers
NVIDIA GeForce 7300GT, 7300GS,
6600GT, 6200
ATI X1300XT, X1300Pro, X700, X300

Features

These cards are odd beasts—basically, highly stripped-down versions of their more powerful brethren, they have a particularly difficult audience to please. Such cards need to be powerful enough to warrant purchase in the first place, but also be affordable enough for most, especially since onboard chipsets are getting better and better by the week!

Among the NVIDIA cards, the 6600GTs were the only ones to feature GDDR3. ATI also made a solitary appearance here with the GeCube X1300XT. The additional bandwidth that DDR3 memory provides is pretty impressive, and considering that GDDR3 can scale up to 40 per cent faster clock speeds as compared to DDR2, these cards were bound to have quite an advantage.

Both NVIDIA and ATI cards feature some avatar of the "Shared Memory" technology that is prevalent among the lower-end cards. NVIDIA calls this "TurboCache", while ATI uses the handle "Hypermemory". Very simply, these cards come with less onboard memory (to make them economical), and to make up for this deficiency, they have the ability to utilise additional system memory, which is used as video memory for frame buffering. This process is dynamic, so if more system memory is required by the other components, the controller relinquishes the requisite amount.

